Lesson 33: Pronunciation: Thought Groups

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 4: Education and Creativity

Adapted from Speaking, Listening and Pronunciation Projects for ELLs - Intermediate Level by Brittany Zemlick, Grossmont College (CC BY 4.0): 4.5: Thought Groups.

In this lesson

English speakers divide what they say into short phrases called thought groups. In this lesson you learn to hear the pauses between thought groups and the one strong word in each group. You practice with four recordings you know from this course, and you record yourself reading part of Sir Ken Robinson's story.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain what a thought group and a focus word are.
- Mark the pauses (/) in a transcript while you listen.
- Find the focus word in each thought group.
- Use the right intonation on the focus word: up on the focus word, then down at the end of the group.
- Read a paragraph aloud with natural pauses and record yourself.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
thought group	a short phrase with one idea; you say it together and then pause	While I love learning English, / I don't have time to do the homework, / …
pause	a short stop when you speak	Thought groups are usually followed by a brief pause.
brief	short	a brief pause
focus word	the word with the strongest stress and the most importance in a thought group	taking tests makes me **NER·vous**
stress	saying a word or syllable more strongly than the others	Which words are stressed in sentence 2?
intonation	the music of speech: the voice goes up and down	The intonation usually goes up on the focus word.
transcript	the written words of a recording	Listen to the recording and read the transcript.

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
underline	draw a line under a word	Underline the stressed word in each thought group.
emphasize	say a word more strongly	Emphasize the most important word in each thought group.
slash (/)	the mark you write where the speaker pauses	Write a "/" when he pauses.

Rules and explanations

What is a thought group?

- English speakers divide language into phrases called thought groups.
- Compare the book's warm-up sentence. The second version has pauses between the thought groups:
  1. While I love learning English, I don't have time to do the homework, and taking tests makes me nervous.
  2. While I love learning English, / I don't have time to do the homework, / and taking tests makes me nervous.

Rules to remember

- A thought group usually has **one focus word**.
- The focus word (the word with the strongest stress and the most importance) is **often at the end** of the thought group.
- The intonation usually **goes up on the focus word** and then **down at the end** of each thought group.
- A thought group is usually followed by a **brief pause**.

How to say a thought group

- Say the words inside a group together, without stopping.
- Make the focus word stronger. Then pause briefly and start the next group.
- Commas often show a pause, as in the warm-up sentence. Keep the words of one phrase together, for example "a learning disorder" or "to her parents".

How to mark a transcript

- Draw a / each time the speaker pauses.
- Underline the focus word in each thought group. In this guide, **bold** shows the focus word, and CAPITALS show its stressed syllable.

Practice

1. Warm up. Play the book's recording `Thought_Groups_Warm_Up.m4a`. It is on your computer in the folder `E:\personal-tutor\materials\library\esl-b1-speaking\attachments\04.05-thought-groups\`, and on the original web page (see "Watch online"). The speaker reads the sentence in two ways (see above). Which one is easier to understand? Which words are stressed in sentence 2? Underline them. Why are they stressed?

2. Watch the video "Pausing within Sentences - Elemental English" (see "Watch online").

3. Mark four transcripts. The transcripts are in your printed lesson. For each one: play the video, read the transcript, and draw a / each time the speaker pauses. Then underline the stressed word in each thought group. Play it again to check.

- a. 25 Things to Do in Berlin (00:00 to 00:33)
- b. Andy's Job (1:06 to 2:39)
- c. Zero Waste Toothpaste (00:00 to 00:22)
- d. TED Talk: Do Schools Kill Creativity? (15:19 to 15:43)

4. Record: thought groups. Use the TED Talk paragraph that begins "Gillian and I had lunch one day." Listen to the video again.

- Write a / when Sir Ken Robinson pauses and underline the stressed word in each thought group.
- Practice reading the paragraph aloud.
- When you are ready, make a video of yourself with your phone reading the paragraph. Pause in the correct places and emphasize the most important word in each thought group.
- Watch your video. Did you pause at each /? Did you make one word stronger in each group?

Speak with your tutor

- "Read this sentence two ways, without pauses and then with pauses: While I love learning English, I don't have time to do the homework, and taking tests makes me nervous. Ask me which way was easier to understand."
- "I will read the Ken Robinson paragraph with pauses. Tell me if any pause sounded strange or if I stopped in the middle of a phrase."
- "Ask me three questions about my school days. I will answer in long sentences and pause between thought groups. Tell me if my answers were easy to follow."
- "I will retell what Andy does in his job, in short thought groups. Then ask me one question about it."

Read aloud

- While I love learning **ENG·lish**, / I don't have time to do the **HOME·work**, / and taking tests makes me **NER·vous**. (↘)
- Gillian and I had **LUNCH** one day. (↘)

- I said, / "How did you get to be a **DAN·cer**?" (↘)
- When she was at **SCHOOL**, / she was really **HOPE·less**. (↘)
- She couldn't **CON·cen·trate**; / she was **FID·get·ing**. (↘)
- It wasn't an **a·VAIL·a·ble** condition. (↘)
- People weren't **a·WARE** they could have that. (↘)

Watch online

- Pausing within Sentences - Elemental English: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=YyY63ivixOs
- 25 Things to Do in Berlin (watch 00:00 to 00:33): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=lw5NHQeXzpA
- Andy's Job (watch 1:06 to 2:39): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Wa0582oOYgY&t=66s
- Zero Waste Toothpaste (watch 00:00 to 00:22): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=DIpTXQl7qTo
- TED Talk "Do Schools Kill Creativity?" (watch 15:19 to 15:43): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=iG9CE55wbtY&t=919s (the book's link: https://www.ted.com/talks/sir_ken_robinson_do_schools_kill_creativity)
- Original web page of this lesson, with the warm-up recording: https://human.libretexts.org/Bookshelves/Languages/English_as_a_Second_Language/Book%3A_Speaking_Listening_and_Pronunciation_Projects_for_ELLs_-_Intermediate_Level_(Zemlick)/04%3A_Education_and_Creativity/4.05%3A_Thought_Groups

Answer key

1. The book gives no answer. Sentence 2 has pauses between the thought groups, and that is what makes speech easier to understand. For the stressed words, check what you hear in the recording. The rules in this lesson say the focus word is often the last important word of each group: here that would be ENG·lish, HOME·work and NER·vous. Focus words are stressed because they carry the most important information.

2. No answer needed.

3. The book gives no answer key. Your marks must follow what you hear in each video. Then read your marked transcript aloud to your tutor and ask if the pauses sound natural.

4. The book gives no answer key: mark the pauses that you hear in the video. For your own reading, here is one natural way to divide the paragraph (example answer). It is not a record of Sir Ken Robinson's pauses. Gillian and I had **LUNCH** one day. / I said, / "How did you get to be a **DAN·cer**?" / It was **IN·ter·est·ing**. / When she was at **SCHOOL**, / she was really **HOPE·less**. / And the **SCHOOL**, / in the **'30s**, / wrote to her **PAR·ents** / and **SAID**, / "We think Gillian has a learning **dis·OR·der**." / She couldn't **CON·cen·trate**; / she was **FID·get·ing**. / I think now / they'd say she had **ADHD**. / Wouldn't **YOU**? / But this was the **1930s**, / and ADHD hadn't been **in·VENT·ed** / at this **POINT**. / It wasn't an **a·VAIL·a·ble** condition. / People weren't **a·WARE** they could have that. Note: "the '30s" and "the 1930s" are said "the thirties" and "the nineteen thirties". ADHD is said as four letters: A-D-H-D.

My notes